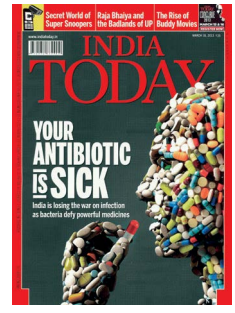
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

India has the dubious distinction of being the diabetes capital of the world and being among the top three countries for obesity. The Indian Council of Medical Research-India Diabetes study 2023 estimated there were 101 million diabetics and 136 million pre-diabetics in India in 2021. That's a sick population that is bigger than the entire population of Brazil. Data from the latest National Family Health Survey for 2019-21 (NFHS-5) revealed that 24 per cent of Indian women and 22.9 per cent of men are overweight or obese. Worse, 56.7 per cent of women and 47.7 per cent of men have abdominal obesity. So, the discovery of the active ingredient called semaglutide by Danish pharma giant Novo Nordisk, which led to the development of the new diabetes drug Ozempic, holds special significance for India. Ozempic and its variants are taking the world by storm with their dramatic new benefits because it was soon discovered that the anti-diabetic formulation had the add-on benefit of being able to reduce obesity.

After January 2022, when Novo Nordisk did the India launch of Rybelsus, the oral version of Ozempic, the pill did not take long to see whole-hearted adoption. Like Ozempic, the appeal of Rybelsus lies in its double-plus value. First, its original role as an anti-diabetes medicine, helping increase the insulin production capacity of the pancreas, a vital organ in the abdomen usually impaired in diabetic patients. These drugs coax the pancreas to secrete more insulin, thereby controlling a patient's blood sugar levels. On top of that, they result in the suppression of hunger. By slowing down the passage of food through our digestive system, semaglutide helps signal satiety to the brain. Thus, it helps curb 'food noise' or cravings, especially from hedonic hunger, where we eat for pleasure, rather than any actual need for it. The normal type of hunger, which strikes when we genuinely need food for nutrition, is called homeostatic hunger.



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Internationally, in the image-conscious society we all live in, it was no surprise that it's the weight-loss abilities of the semaglutide drugs that drew more attention. Seeing the demand for a purely weight loss drug, Novo Nordisk duly came out with an injectable anti-obesity drug with a higher dose of semaglutide than Ozempic and branded it under the name Wegovy. The approval from the US Food and Drug Administration (FDA) for Wegovy came in 2021. A parallel 16-nation trial beginning 2021 confirmed that, over a year and four months, weekly semaglutide ingestion decreased body weight by nearly 15 per cent. With international celebrities like Elon Musk and Oprah Winfrey endorsing the drug, Wegovy gained a cult-like status. Sales of both Ozempic and Wegovy skyrocketed, leading to a worldwide shortage. Now, instead, of using it for treatment of diabetes and clinical obesity, it was being bought for vanity weight loss.

This soon set off a race. In November 2023, American pharma giant Eli Lilly introduced Zepbound, another medication based on a glucose-lowering ingredient called tirzepatide that promises a five per cent extra reduction in weight as compared to Wegovy. However, Wegovy came back strongly when the FDA, on March 8, approved it for cardiac benefits as well. This came on the back of a five-year trial that showed semaglutide cut adverse cardiovascular events, including heart attacks and strokes, by 28 per cent in non-diabetic obese patients with underlying heart conditions. The general cardio-protective effect was said to be around 20 per cent. This dramatically widens the spectrum of potential use.

In India, Rybelsus is the only semaglutide form Novo Nordisk is currently marketing, as a prescription drug for diabetes. Wegovy is reportedly planned for a 2026 launch. But we apparently already have the beginnings of a buzzing grey market. Though approved in the US as a weight loss drug for only clinically obese people, its off-label use for vanity weight loss is becoming rampant. Elite Indians are aping Hollywood A-listers in trying to get their hands on the 'skinny pen'—as an Ozempic or Wegovy injection is called. "It is being seen by people worldwide, including in India, as a blockbuster agent for weight loss," says Dr Srinivasa P. Munigoti, consultant endocrinologist at Fortis Hospital, Bengaluru.

Are Ozempic, Wegovy, Rybelsus, Zepbound and its variant Mounjaro, then, the miracle drugs we have been looking for all these years? Celeb testimonies, great marketing and desperation may certainly lead us to believe so, but a bit of circumspection may not be amiss. These drugs do have serious side-effects if used indiscriminately. Semaglutide ingestion is known to at times induce gastrointestinal issues like nausea, vomiting, abdominal pain and, in extreme cases, pancreatitis and even stomach paralysis. In rare instances, it can also induce cancers of the thyroid and endocrine glands. More than anything, their relative newness means no data exists yet on their long-term impact. Certainly, unlike for diabetes or clinical obesity, prolonged use will be meaningless for ordinary weight loss. Because you will presumably achieve your target weight at some point. And the moment you stop it, the weight returns with a vengeance, without lifestyle or dietary modifications. Cyclical loss or gain of weight can also result in injury to cells, setting off another cascade of complications.

Furthermore, there have been no trials of the drugs in Indian settings, studying their impact in terms specific to the Indian body type. We only formed part of the worldwide trials. The drugs are also an expensive proposition, with a monthly dose of Ozempic costing $936 (approx. Rs 77,474) and Wegovy $1,300 (Rs 1.07 lakh) in the US and a 10-tablet strip of Rybelsus costing upwards of Rs 3,000. In a country where families can spend only an average of 7.9 per cent of their annual household consumption expenditure on healthcare, not many will be able to afford these drugs. Senior Associate Editor Sonali Acharjee, in our cover story this week, deliberates on the promise and perils these drugs may hold for Indians. Wonder drugs like these may make us optimistic about a cure for some endemic problems, but the best cure for diabetes and weight loss is lifestyle changes. Otherwise, they can be a curse.



(Aroon Purie)